



Tense finish: Shardul Thakur's valiant half-century wasn't enough as defending champion Mumbai fell to last year's finalist Vidarbha in a gripping Ranji Trophy semifinal. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Vidarbha's celebrations, Kerala's composure — two semifinals, one dream

Our correspondents bring you the **highlights and intriguing moments**, both on and off the field, from the Ranji Trophy semifinals.

Beating Pakistan has often been considered as good as winning the World Cup for India's men's cricket team — at least until a decade ago. Similarly, in the Ranji Trophy, most teams, throughout the tournament's nine-decade history, have treated their fixture against Mumbai with a similar sense of occasion.

While every team dreams of lifting the Ranji Trophy, facing Mumbai has always carried an added sense of challenge — often evoking a sentiment of "let's hope for the best." Little wonder, then, that the Vidarbha



Cricket Association (VCA) wore a festive look after the home side triumphed over the domestic powerhouse in the semifinal, winning by 80 runs. Despite Vidarbha having defeated Mumbai at the same venue six years ago, celebrations erupted at the greens of Jamtha minutes after Ajinkya Rahane returned to the dressing room following his post-match media interaction. Vidarbha players' families, former cricketers, association members, and a select group of privileged fans in the members' stands all gathered on the ground alongside VCA officials to revel in the team's convincing victory